

TWB Designs

GLOBAL CONFLICT BRIEF · EDITION 001 · 25 AUGUST 2026 · INTERNAL

A standing survey of armed conflict worldwide, maintained daily. Each conflict carries a status line, a dated change log, and an ordnance signal — the materiel consequence, which is the part that bears on this business. The closing section reads the whole picture against TWB's market. The brief is written to be useful to someone deciding where to put money and people, not to persuade anyone of anything.

Standing rules. Every figure carries its source and the date that source published it. Statements by a party to a conflict are labelled *claim* and are never presented as fact. Figures that circulate widely but cannot be traced to a primary document are excluded, and the significant exclusions are listed in the closing note. Where two credible bodies disagree, both are given. Where a number is stale, its vintage is stated. Nothing here is advocacy for any party.

↗ improving · ↘ deteriorating — the net direction of each situation over the last 30–60 days, not its absolute severity. A deteriorating mark on a quiet file and on a war mean very different things; read it against the status line.

1 — THE GLOBAL PICTURE

INDICATOR	LATEST	SOURCE & PUBLICATION DATE
State-based armed conflicts, 2025	65	UCDP, <i>Journal of Peace Research</i> 63(4), 9 Jun 2026
Of which interstate	8 — highest since 1946	UCDP, 9 Jun 2026
Conflicts meeting the "war" threshold	13 — highest since 1992	UCDP, 9 Jun 2026
Deaths in organised violence, 2025	~244,600	UCDP, 9 Jun 2026 — 2nd deadliest year since 1994
Of which one-sided violence	~76,500	UCDP, 9 Jun 2026 — highest since 1994; Sudan-driven
Russia–Ukraine share of battle deaths	~62% (94,700)	UCDP, 9 Jun 2026
World military expenditure, 2025	US\$2,887bn, +2.9%	SIPRI Fact Sheet, Apr 2026 — 11th consecutive rise
Europe / Asia-Oceania spend	\$864bn +14% / \$681bn +8.1%	SIPRI, Apr 2026 — largest Asian rise since 2009
Global arms transfer volume	+9.2%	SIPRI, 9 Mar 2026 — biggest rise since 2011–15
Forced displacement, end-2025	117.8m, –4%	UNHCR Global Trends, 11 Jun 2026 — first fall in a decade
Mine/ERW casualties, 2024	6,279 (1,945 killed)	Landmine Monitor 2025, 1 Dec 2025
International mine-action funding, 2024	\$761m, –5%	Landmine Monitor 2025, 1 Dec 2025

What the aggregate says. More conflicts than at any point in the post-1945 record, more of them between states, and more money going into weapons — while the displacement figure falls for the first time in ten years because 14.7 million people returned home in 2025 (UNHCR, 11 Jun 2026). Return is the operative word: people are moving back into ground that was fought over, which converts a wartime hazard into a peacetime one. Against that, the money for clearing that ground fell 5% in 2024 and the largest donor cut deeply in 2025. The gap between materiel produced and materiel accounted for is the widest it has been in the modern record, and no published policy or funding line addresses the disposal side of it.

AT A GLANCE — THE DIRECTION OF EACH SECTION

SECTION	THE READ	MOVING THE OTHER WAY
Europe & Eurasia ✓	Ukraine at its deadliest month for civilians since May 2022 and talks rejected outright; Russian munitions now landing on NATO soil as a persistent pattern rather than an incident.	Türkiye–PKK. A reintegration law passed 10 Aug and camps in Duhok have been vacated — the only file in Europe moving toward disarmament.
Middle East & North Africa ✓	Gaza's ceasefire holding on paper through its deadliest month of the year; the Iran negotiating window expired 17 Aug with Hormuz still closed; Lebanon's ceasefire violated continuously.	Syria. SDF integration declared complete 21 Aug, an assembly seated, OPCW rights restored — a transition consolidating rather than fracturing.
Africa ✓	Sudan remains the deadliest war in the world with 200,000+ newly displaced in Kordofan; South Sudan back at open war; the Sahel shifting from insurgency to economic strangulation.	DR Congo. A negotiating roadmap agreed 21 Aug, first ceasefire verification 24 Aug, and an FDLR disarmament plan formally tabled.
Asia-Pacific ✓	Myanmar second only to Syria for mine casualties with no DDR mechanism of any kind; the Thai–Cambodian ceasefire eroding through mine casualties while talks stay frozen.	Nothing material. The nearest thing is the Philippines, where the 14 September BARMM elections could restart a frozen MILF handover — a possibility, not yet a movement.
The Americas ✓	Colombia's "Total Peace" negotiations ended with the 7 August change of government; Haiti's suppression force at a fifth of its authorised strength; US strikes extending onto land.	Nothing material in the last 60 days.

Every section is deteriorating on net, and three of the five have a genuine counter-trend inside them. Those counter-trends — Türkiye, Syria, the DRC — are where disarmament is actually happening, and they are where the commercial reading on the closing page concentrates. A war getting worse produces contamination that someone eventually pays to clear; a war being wound up produces weapons that someone has to destroy on a schedule. The second is the nearer business.

2 — EUROPE & EURASIA

Russia–Ukraine ✓

Active, high intensity. No ceasefire. Negotiations stalled. The only truce of 2026 was a 32-hour Orthodox Easter pause, 11–13 April, not renewed. (ISW/Critical Threats, Russian Offensive Campaign Assessment, 23 Aug 2026)

19–20 Aug — large combined missile and drone strike; a children's hospital in Kyiv damaged, at least 12 killed. (ISW, 20 Aug 2026)

22 Aug — Putin publicly dismissed peace proposals as "exotic" and "unacceptable," insisting any talks reflect "ground realities." (ISW, 22 Aug 2026)

~22–23 Aug — Zelensky announced a joint Ukraine–US–Europe proposal: ceasefire, mutual withdrawal, EU/NATO guarantees. Rejected by Moscow. (ISW, 23 Aug 2026)

12 Aug — UN OHCHR reported **437 civilians killed and 2,610 injured in July 2026** — the highest monthly toll since May 2022, up 30% on June and 70% on July 2025. First half of 2026: 1,396 killed, 7,978 injured. (OHCHR HRMMU, 12 Aug 2026)

30 Jul — Russia extended its fuel export ban to January 2027, a direct consequence of Ukrainian refinery strikes. (ICG CrisisWatch, Jul 2026)

Main Russian effort has shifted to the Slovyansk axis, with pressure at Hulyaipole and in northern Sumy. Short-range drones near the front line now account for 27% of all civilian casualties — the highest share of the war. (ISW, 14–23 Aug 2026; OHCHR, 12 Aug 2026)

Ordnance signal. Russian output reached ~7 million artillery shells, mortar rounds and rockets in 2025 — more than seventeenfold the ~400,000 baseline of 2021 (Estonian Foreign Intelligence Service, 10 Feb 2026). Ukraine's confirmed landmine contamination stands at 105.88 km² with 28.37 km² released in 2024 (Landmine & Cluster Munition Monitor country profile); the Ukrainian government's working figure of ~139,000 km² is a *potentially hazardous area* survey estimate, not confirmed contamination, and the two must not be conflated. Ukrainian mine/ERW casualties: 275 in 2025, 293 in 2024 (ICBL-CMC preliminary data, Jun 2026).

WHY IT STARTED

Russia annexed Crimea and backed an armed separatist movement in the Donbas in **2014**, after Ukraine's Maidan protests removed a president who had rejected an EU association agreement. Eight years of low-intensity war in the east followed under the unimplemented Minsk agreements. Russia invaded on **24 February 2022**, stating aims of "demilitarisation" and preventing NATO enlargement; Ukraine and its partners characterise it as a war of territorial conquest. Neither framing is adjudicated here. What is not disputed: no ceasefire has held, Moscow's stated territorial demands have expanded since 2022 to include buffer zones beyond Donbas, and the war is now the deadliest interstate conflict since 1945.

NATO's eastern flank — Baltic, Nordic, Poland, Romania ✓

No armed conflict. A new incident category has persisted since March 2026: Russian and stray Ukrainian munitions arriving on allied territory, with two NATO air-to-air engagements over allied soil and live warheads recovered on the ground. (National defence ministries; Reuters; ISW)

30 Jul — a Russian Kh-101 cruise missile detonated at Tarnawa-Kolonia, eastern Poland, leaving a ~10 m crater; Polish authorities confirmed a "significant amount" of explosive material. No injuries. NATO SG Rutte called it "a dangerous consequence" of the war. (Al Jazeera, 30 Jul 2026; Notes from Poland, 31 Jul 2026)

24–26 Jul — Romania intercepted three suspected Russian drones. (ICG CrisisWatch, Jul 2026)

20 Aug — Russian drones penetrated Moldovan and Romanian airspace; a Russian naval drone was destroyed near Romania's Neptune Deep gas platform. (ISW, 20 Aug 2026)

Earlier establishing sequence: a Romanian F-16 downed a drone over Estonia (19 May), a French Rafale destroyed one over Latvia (8 Jun), a drone exploded at the Rēzekne oil facility (7 May), and two drones fell near Kouvola, Finland — **one with an unexploded warhead** (30 Mar). Latvia's defence minister resigned. (National authorities, Mar–Jun 2026)

Ordnance signal. Five states have now completed withdrawal from the Anti-Personnel Mine Ban Convention — Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania on 27 Dec 2025, Finland on 10 Jan 2026, Poland on **20 Feb 2026** (UN Treaty Collection, Ch. XXVI-5; 162 states parties remain). Finland, Lithuania and Poland have signalled intent to restart anti-personnel mine production (Arms Control Association, Jan 2026). Mines emplaced on the eastern flank are a clearance liability that will outlive whatever they are meant to deter. Live warhead recovery in Finland is already an EOD workload for national authorities.

WHY IT IS STARTING

This is not a war and has no declared origin — it is spillover becoming a pattern. From **March 2026**, as Ukraine's deep-strike campaign reached Russian Baltic-coast oil terminals and Russia's drone campaign intensified, munitions from both sides began arriving on NATO soil: Ukrainian strike drones losing navigation to Russian jamming, and Russian drones and one cruise missile crossing directly. Each government contests the cause — Ukraine cites interference, Russia accuses the Baltic states of providing transit airspace, the Baltic states reject both. The mechanism that would turn this into a conflict is arithmetic rather than intent: no incident has yet produced a casualty, and an Article 4 or 5 consultation almost certainly follows the one that does.

Moldova / Transnistria

Frozen but actively destabilising. No hostilities. The Moldovan government resigned 3 July 2026 and remains caretaker; Russia signed a decree in mid-May simplifying citizenship for Transnistria residents, which President Sandu characterised publicly as a recruitment instrument. (Al Jazeera, 3 Jul 2026; Bloomberg, 16 May 2026)

20 Aug — Russian drones crossed Moldovan airspace; Sandu stated Russia "deliberately launches some of its drones" across borders — a hardening of Chisinau's public position. (ISW, 20 Aug 2026)

Mar 2026 — Moldova circulated a 14-page reintegration plan: no special status for Transnistria, an internationally appointed transitional administration, and Russian withdrawal under international supervision. (Carnegie, 31 Mar 2026)

Ordnance signal — the largest unmanaged stockpile in Europe outside the war. The Cobasna depot holds up to 20,000 tonnes of Soviet-era ammunition inherited from the 14th Guards Army, guarded by roughly 1,500 Operational Group personnel. The OSCE has never been granted access to assess its condition. No disposal, demilitarisation or DDR programme exists for it, and Moldova's March plan does not address it. *Note: the widely circulated "Hiroshima-equivalent" characterisation of a Cobasna detonation cannot be traced to a published technical study and is physically implausible for 20,000 t of conventional ordnance. It is excluded here.*

WHY IT STARTED

Transnistria, a Russian-speaking industrial strip on the Dniester, fought a brief war against Moldova in **1992** as the USSR dissolved, backed by the Soviet 14th Guards Army stationed there. The war ended in a ceasefire that froze the line and left Russian troops in place as "peacekeepers" — along with the army's ammunition, which became the Cobasna stockpile. Nothing has been settled in thirty-four years. The file reactivated because Moldova turned decisively toward the EU, and Moscow responded with citizenship, energy and trade instruments rather than force.

Türkiye–PKK — the live DDR case

Peace and reintegration process advancing. Parliament passed a 12-article reintegration law on **10 August 2026** by **468 votes to 88**. (Reuters, 10 Aug 2026)

The law suspends sentences for some convicted members and defers investigations for 5–10 years, dismissing them if no terror offence follows. It excludes those convicted of intentional killings and pre-2005 life sentences — including Abdullah Öcalan.

Critical condition: the law takes effect only once Türkiye's National Security Council confirms the PKK has disbanded and **surrendered all weapons**. It is currently inert. Eligible individuals then have six months to apply.

Early Jul — PKK vacated the Siyani camp and Bahar Tepe area in Duhok, Iraqi Kurdistan; Turkish forces moved in. First verified physical demobilisation step of 2026. (ICG CrisisWatch, Jul 2026)

PKK's public response calls the law seriously deficient and demands Öcalan's release and political reforms. Weapons surrender has not begun.

Ordinance signal. A completed surrender produces a substantial cache of small arms, light weapons, ammunition and IED components spanning Turkish and Iraqi Kurdish jurisdictions. **No verification mechanism, third-party monitor or destruction programme has been publicly named.** That absence is the single clearest gap in the process — and the most direct read-across to a verified, in-place destruction capability anywhere in this brief.

WHY IT STARTED, AND WHY IT MAY END

The PKK took up arms in **1984** for Kurdish self-rule in south-eastern Türkiye; the conflict has killed tens of thousands over four decades and repeatedly failed to settle — most recently when talks collapsed in 2015. What changed was strategic rather than moral: the PKK's regional position weakened as Syria's war reordered Kurdish politics, and Ankara found domestic political use for a settlement. Öcalan called for dissolution from prison in 2025; the group declared it and began withdrawing. This is the one file in the brief moving toward resolution rather than away from it — and it is the one that most obviously needs a destruction mechanism it does not have.

South Caucasus and the Western Balkans — in brief

Armenia–Azerbaijan: the peace agreement remains *initialled*, not signed, one year after the White House summit; Baku still requires an Armenian constitutional change first. (Joint US–Armenia–Azerbaijan statement, 10 Aug 2026) On 1 July the EU launched a €200m connectivity package plus a €20m "Peace Dividends" programme covering demining among four uses. (European Commission, 1 Jul 2026) ANAMA reports 287,385 hectares cleared cumulatively in the returned territories, finding roughly 130–790 mines and 330–2,100 UXO per month (ANAMA via APA, 2026 — government-agency figures).

Kosovo: the Constitutional Court's 7 August deadline to constitute the Assembly passed with no legal remedy — an unprecedented constitutional vacuum in a jurisdiction with an unresolved security problem in its north. (European Western Balkans, 10 Aug 2026)

Bosnia: general elections 4 October; EUFOR Althea's authorisation expires 31 October and must clear the Security Council before then. (Security Council Report, May 2026)

Serbia: ammunition exports have been halted since 26 June 2025, with National Security Council approval now required per export. (RFE/RL)

Ordinance signal. The Western Balkans SALW Control Roadmap (SEESAC / UNDP / UNODC) remains the standing regional framework for weapons collection, surplus ammunition destruction and stockpile-security upgrades. Current tonnages and 2026 targets are not published — a gap flagged for the next edition.

WHY THEY STARTED

Armenia–Azerbaijan: both claimed Nagorno-Karabakh as the USSR collapsed; war in 1988–94 left Armenian forces holding the enclave and surrounding districts, Azerbaijan retook them in 2020 and 2023, and virtually the entire ethnic Armenian population left. The mines were laid across three decades of that. **The Balkans:** Yugoslavia's dissolution in the 1990s produced settlements — Dayton in Bosnia (1995), an unrecognised Kosovar independence (2008) — that ended the fighting without resolving the underlying question of who the state belongs to. Both remain political crises with armed histories, not armed conflicts.

3 – MIDDLE EAST & NORTH AFRICA

Israel–Gaza ✓

The 10 October 2025 ceasefire formally holds and is violated continuously. A Hamas weapons-decommissioning agreement was announced 30–31 July 2026; Israel and Hamas are deadlocked over whether disarmament or withdrawal comes first. (OCHA oPt, 14 Aug 2026; Chatham House, 3 Aug 2026)

30–31 Jul — Board of Peace agreement published. Weapons to be inventoried, decommissioned and **stored** — under a Palestinian National Committee, which becomes "the sole entity to hold, store or control weapons in Gaza." No weapons transfer to Israel or non-Palestinian parties. First tranche: heavy weapons, production sites, depots, tunnels. Verification by an International Verification Committee. (Al Jazeera, 31 Jul 2026; full text via Times of Israel)

4 Aug — Board of Peace director Mladenov set sequencing: no Israeli withdrawal beyond the Yellow Line until decommissioning is complete. Hamas rejected sequential ordering. (Al Jazeera, 4 Aug 2026)

7 Aug — OCHA recorded July 2026 as the deadliest month of the year inside the ceasefire, over 150 fatalities. Cumulative since the ceasefire: 1,259 killed, 4,148 injured (Gaza Ministry of Health via OCHA, 14 Aug 2026); 804 bodies retrieved from rubble as of 5 Aug.

26–28 Jul — Israeli cabinet approved entry of an International Stabilisation Force; **7 Aug** — Uganda's parliament approved a troop deployment to it.

2.1 million people remain in less than half the Strip; water insecurity at 90%, up from 84% in June; the 2026 oPt Flash Appeal is 37.5% funded, with \$2.5bn unmet. (OCHA, 7 & 14 Aug 2026)

Ordnance signal — the largest ERW caseload in the region. 589 explosive-ordnance incidents since October 2023 have killed 274 people and injured 1,142 (OCHA, 14 Aug 2026). UNMAS has identified and marked 1,052 EO items across 9 km² assessed, and is requesting an *additional* \$9.2m to sustain the response through 2026. UNDP assesses **61 million tonnes** of rubble — contaminated with explosives, asbestos and medical waste — clearable in seven years under permissive conditions, needing \$110m now (UNDP, 20 Nov 2025). MAG relays a UN order-of-magnitude estimate of ~200,000 tonnes of ammunition expended, implying tens of thousands of tonnes of UXO, and assesses first-pass clearance of priority areas at five years minimum, full clearance in decades. **The decommissioning agreement provides for storage, not destruction.** If that modality shifts — and stored caches under contested custody historically do not stay stored — the requirement becomes a procurement question rather than a political one.

WHY IT STARTED

The immediate war began with the Hamas-led attack on southern Israel on **7 October 2023** and Israel's military response in Gaza. The longer origin is the unresolved status of the territory: Israel occupied Gaza in 1967, withdrew settlers and forces in 2005 while retaining control of its borders, airspace and sea access, and Hamas took control of the Strip in 2007, after which Israel and Egypt imposed a blockade. Every element of that sequence is contested in its framing by the parties. What is not contested is the physical result — roughly two years of high-intensity urban warfare in a dense, enclosed strip, which is why the ERW and rubble caseload above is the largest in the region.

Israel–Lebanon / Hezbollah ✓

Ceasefire since 1 June 2026 after a war that ran from 2 March; violated continuously. (Al Jazeera, 16 Aug 2026; ACLED, 20 Aug 2026)

15–16 Aug — Israeli strikes across Nabatieh district killed at least 11, per Lebanese reporting. (Al Jazeera, 16 Aug 2026 — attributed, not independently verified)

20 Aug — ACLED published an explicit escalation-risk assessment on attrition around the Ali al-Taher ridge.

Early Aug — seventh round of Israel–Lebanon talks held; an eighth expected in September.

UNIFIL's mandate terminates 31 December 2026 — a final extension under S/RES/2790 (28 Aug 2025). The Secretary-General's letter S/2026/453 (1 Jun 2026) sets out options for implementing Resolution 1701 after withdrawal.

Ordinance signal — the region's clearest precedent. On 9 August 2025 six Lebanese Armed Forces soldiers, four from the 5th Infantry Brigade and two from the Engineering Regiment, were killed when Hezbollah ammunition detonated during a removal-and-dismantling operation at Majdal Zoun, Tyre — work mandated by the ceasefire and Resolution 1701 (Arab News; Lebanese Presidential Palace statement). A state army destroying seized ammunition in the field, taking fatalities doing it. UNIFIL's departure removes the principal international EOD and monitoring presence in south Lebanon at the end of this year, and nothing has been named to replace that function.

WHY IT STARTED

Hezbollah formed during Israel's 1982 invasion of Lebanon and has fought Israel intermittently since, most heavily in 2006. The current round began when Hezbollah opened fire in support of Hamas on **8 October 2023**, escalating through 2024 into an Israeli air and ground campaign, then a November 2024 ceasefire that neither side fully implemented. Fighting resumed in full on **2 March 2026** and ran until the 1 June ceasefire. The unresolved question underneath is Resolution 1701's core demand — that no armed group other than the Lebanese state operate south of the Litani — which has never been enforced, and which UNIFIL's departure at the end of this year leaves no one assigned to enforce.

Iran, the Gulf, and the Strait of Hormuz ✓

The war that began 28 February 2026 has no formal ceasefire. The 17 June 14-point Memorandum of Understanding's 60-day window expired 17 August with no agreement; the Strait of Hormuz remains effectively closed. (House of Commons Library CBP-10637, 28 Jul 2026; CBS News, 17 Aug 2026)

17 Aug — deadline lapsed. Iran disputes that a 60-day deadline existed. Hormuz throughput: 3–5 vessels over a mid-August weekend against ~130/day pre-war; the UN/IMO gave ~7 ships on a recent Sunday against a ~140 average. (CBS, 17 Aug 2026; UN News, 12 Aug 2026 — two independent sources agreeing on order of magnitude)

27 Feb — the last IAEA-verified enriched uranium figure is **440.9 kg at up to 60%**. The Agency states it cannot verify whether enrichment has been suspended and has lost continuity of knowledge; monitoring is by commercial satellite imagery only. (IAEA GOV/2026/8, 27 Feb 2026)

Jun — first sustained Kurdish insurgent escalation inside Iran since the war began: PJAK clashes from 7 June in Marivan, spreading to Baneh, West Azerbaijan and Kermanshah. (ACLED, 3 Jul 2026)

Gulf states, 28 Feb – 17 May: Iran fired more than **6,700 drones and missiles** at the GCC; the UAE absorbed nearly half. A March strike on Qatar's Ras Laffan removed an estimated 17% of Qatari LNG export capacity. Roughly 28 non-US nationals killed across the six states. (CRS R48971, 3 Jun 2026)

Ordnance signal. CENTCOM reports intercepting over 6,000 one-way attack drones and more than 1,500 ballistic missiles (US military figures — a belligerent's own accounting). Interception is not disposal: intercepted and failed munitions produce debris and unexploded warheads on populated ground and inside critical infrastructure across six small, densely built states. **No published GCC clearance or EOD accounting exists.** That absence, against a verified expenditure of 6,700+ rounds, is itself the finding. On the supply side, the Pentagon signed a \$22.9bn Tomahawk contract in mid-August amid stated munitions-shortage concerns — the industrial posture that historically pulls stockpile turnover and demilitarisation budgets along behind it.

WHY IT STARTED

Iran and Israel have fought through proxies since 1979 and directly since April 2024. The current war began with a **US–Israeli strike campaign on 28 February 2026**, in which Ali Khamenei was killed; the stated rationale was Iran's nuclear programme, which the IAEA had reported at 440.9 kg of uranium enriched to 60% and which it has been unable to verify since. Iran responded by firing on the Gulf states hosting US forces and by closing the Strait of Hormuz. The Gulf states are in this war because of geography and basing, not because they chose a side — which is why their intercept debris is an unowned clearance problem no one has budgeted for.

Syria ↗

Transition consolidating politically; Suwayda outside effective state control. A People's Assembly seated 12 July; SDF military, security and administrative integration declared complete 21 August. (Security Council Report, Aug 2026; The National, 21 Aug 2026)

21 Aug — Mazloum Abdi declared integration complete; tens of thousands of SDF personnel now on Syrian government payrolls. Constitutional entrenchment of Kurdish rights remains unresolved.

19 Aug — Israel struck Abu Duhur air base in Idlib, eight strikes damaging the runway, citing an imminent Turkish troop deployment. Turkey and Syria both condemned it. **24 Aug** — US-mediated Syria–Israel talks resumed in Jordan. (NPR, 19 Aug 2026; Al Jazeera, 24 Aug 2026)

Jul — OPCW Executive Council reinstated Syria's rights and privileges, suspended since April 2021. Latest Director-General progress report EC-113/DG.6, 24 Aug 2026.

~1.7 million refugees and ~1.9 million IDPs have returned since December 2024; only one-third of the 2026 humanitarian appeal is funded. (Security Council Report, Aug 2026)

Ordnance signal — the richest file in the region. The OPCW has maintained a continuous presence in Syria since November 2025 specifically to facilitate "inventory, destruction and verification-related activities," and in **May 2026 an OPCW expert team found chemical weapons previously undeclared to the Organisation** (OPCW, May 2026). Separately, the 21 August integration transfers a large SDF inventory — including heavy weapons and US-supplied materiel — into state custody, with **no public accounting of that inventory in existence.** On 24 July 2025 an ammunition warehouse detonated at Maarat Misrin, Idlib: 7 killed and 157 wounded per the Health Ministry, with other reporting higher.

WHY IT STARTED

Syria's war began with protests in **March 2011** and the Assad government's armed suppression of them, fragmenting into a multi-sided conflict drawing in Russia, Iran, Türkiye, the US and Islamic State. Assad's government fell in **December 2024** to a rebel offensive, and the country has been in transition since. The fighting now is not the old war: it is the ordinary violence of a state being rebuilt — factions integrating or refusing to, communal reprisals on the coast and in Suwayda, ISIS remnants, and a neighbour striking to shape the outcome. The chemical-weapons and heavy-weapons inventories are the physical residue of the previous regime, now changing custody.

Iraq, Yemen, Libya, West Bank — in brief ✓

Iraq. Following the US-Israeli strike campaign against Iran-aligned militias (Mar–Apr 2026, ceasefire 7 April), Baghdad ran a militia disarmament process. Asaib Ahl al-Haq and Kataib Imam Ali announced disarmament plans on 2 June and Saraya al-Salam transferred weapons; Kataib Hezbollah and others refused. **Correction carried into this edition:** on 21–24 August both the PM's security adviser and the government spokesman publicly disavowed the reported September weapons-surrender deadline — "September 30 is the date for the international coalition to depart, not the deadline to hand over weapons." No replacement date has been set. (Arab News, Aug 2026) The PMF numbers roughly 230,000–238,000 personnel on a ~\$3.5bn annual budget (FPRI, Mar 2026). Disposal modality for anything surrendered has never been specified.

Yemen. The UN Special Envoy told the Security Council on 13 August that Yemen "faces a more serious risk of return to large-scale conflict than at any point since the 2022 truce." The cargo ship *Tihamah* was attacked 11–12 August, killing three Pakistani and one Indonesian crew. 65 confirmed maritime incidents and 17 deaths since early March; ~6,000 crew and ~500 vessels trapped near Hormuz, 2,900 seafarers evacuated. The 2026 appeal is 20% funded. (UNSC, 13 Aug 2026; UN News/IMO, 12 Aug 2026)

Libya. No general war; entrenched impasse with episodic incidents including drone strikes that set a major oil refinery alight, briefed to the Council 18 August. US mediation is floating a power-sharing arrangement. UNSMIL's mandate runs to October 2026. (UN News, 18 Aug 2026; Security Council Report, Aug 2026) *Libya holds one of the largest uncontrolled conventional-munitions legacies in North Africa and is the weakest-documented file in this brief — flagged for the next edition.*

West Bank. OHCHR describes settler violence at an "unprecedented" level: 1,835 settler attacks in 2025 and roughly 190/month in Jan–Apr 2026. 45 Palestinians killed and 1,089 injured in 2026 to 5 May; 1,021 structures demolished. UNMAS recorded over 2,380 explosive items in the West Bank in 2025 — a small but growing ERW caseload distinct from Gaza's, with 9 EO casualties in Jan–Jul 2026. (UN News, 29 Jul 2026; OCHA; UNMAS oPt)

WHY IT STARTED

The Americas file is not about ideology. **Haiti's** gangs filled the vacuum left by a state that stopped functioning after the 2021 assassination of its president and has held no election since. **Mexico's** cartel conflict escalated when the government militarised counter-narcotics in 2006 and has fragmented with each leader removed since. **Colombia's** war is sixty years old; the 2016 FARC accord ended one part of it and left the ELN and dissident factions in the space it vacated, and the "Total Peace" negotiations that were meant to finish the job ended with the change of government on 7 August 2026. What connects them is that the state is fighting criminal organisations, not armies — which is why the materiel question here is seized property rather than battlefield ordnance.

4 — AFRICA

Sudan — the deadliest conflict in the world ✓

Fourth year. RSF holds all five Darfur states and besieges El Obeid; SAF holds the centre and east. A drone-attrition war with no front-line resolution. (Al Jazeera, 10 & 20 Aug 2026; ACLED Africa Overview, Jul 2026)

20 Aug — IOM reported over **200,000 newly displaced in Kordofan**. El Obeid's population has gone from 750,000 pre-war to an estimated 3.4 million. Nationally: 8.6m currently displaced, ~14m cumulatively, 4.5m returned to areas without basic services. (IOM via Al Jazeera, 20 Aug 2026)

12 Aug — RSF drone strikes disabled El Obeid's power, halting water pumping, hospitals and communications.

11–13 Aug — RSF with SPLM-N captured Geisan (Blue Nile) and retook Kurmuk after SAF withdrew under drone strikes.

27 Jul — SAF seized the Omdurman–El Obeid highway, opening a resupply axis into North Kordofan.

15 May — 19.5 million people in IPC Phase 3+, including **135,000 in Phase 5 Catastrophe across 14 hotspots**; 825,000 children under five expected with severe acute malnutrition in 2026. The Sudan humanitarian plan was 20% funded as of April. (WFP/FAO/UNICEF, 15 May 2026)

~24–25 Aug — the US tabled a proposal to extend the UN arms embargo from Darfur to all of Sudan, explicitly including drones. (Reuters wire, syndicated — confidence medium, primary text not read directly)

Ordnance signal. UNMAS Sudan has released **2,818,890 m²** of land and removed **18,768 explosive ordnance items** since April 2023; in Q1 2026 alone there were 77 EO victims — 25 killed and 52 injured, including 35 children — a figure UNMAS itself calls under-reported. **New minefields have been detected in central Khartoum**, including at a Nile bridge rehabilitation site: contamination being laid *into* return areas. Capacity is five UNMAS teams against 1.5 million returnees. The EU committed €3m over 18 months on 27 April 2026. (UNMAS Sudan Factsheet Q1 2026; EEAS, 27 Apr 2026; UN News, 3 Dec 2025)

WHY THEY STARTED

Iraq: the militias date from the 2014 mobilisation against Islamic State and were made a legal part of the security apparatus; disarming them is a fight over whether Iraq has one army or several. **Yemen:** the Houthis took Sana'a in 2014 and a Saudi-led coalition intervened in 2015; the 2022 truce paused it without settling it, and the Red Sea campaign since 2023 internationalised it. **Libya:** the 2011 uprising and NATO intervention removed Gaddafi and left no state — which is also why Libyan stockpiles have been arming the Sahel for fifteen years. **West Bank:** occupied since 1967; the current violence is settlement expansion and settler action against Palestinian communities, not a war between armies.

Excluded figure. The widely repeated "at least 59,000 killed" is an extrapolation from a Khartoum-state mortality study, not a body count. It is not used here. Event-based counts are lower; true excess mortality is very likely higher. Neither number is a verified national death toll.

South Sudan

The 2018 peace agreement is effectively dead. A rebel offensive that began in late 2025 is now open war in Jonglei and Upper Nile; Machar is detained; elections are nominally scheduled for December 2026. (ICG, 21 Jan 2026; UN Commission on Human Rights in South Sudan, 21 Aug 2026)

21 Aug — the UN Commission reported rising violence and atrocity crimes disrupting the pre-election period.

Jul — President Kiir removed the pre-election requirements from the peace agreement, stripping out the sequencing meant to precede a vote.

Mar — over 100,000 people fled across the border into Ethiopia from Jonglei.

Ordnance signal — the benchmark figure in this brief. UNMAS South Sudan, cumulative to May 2026: **7,298,000 small-arms ammunition items destroyed**, alongside 41,328 landmines, 87,610 cluster munitions and 1,107,000 UXO — 1.236 million explosive devices in total. Delivered by up to nine teams and funded through UN peacekeeping assessed contributions, JICA grants and the South Sudan Humanitarian Fund (UNMAS South Sudan, May 2026). This is the clearest available picture of both the volume and the funding mechanism for institutional small-arms ammunition destruction anywhere — a national programme, assessed-contribution funded, destroying rounds at scale.

WHY IT STARTED

The Rapid Support Forces grew out of the Janjaweed militias of the Darfur war of the 2000s and were institutionalised as a paramilitary force alongside the regular army. Both jointly removed Omar al-Bashir in 2019 and jointly staged a coup against the civilian transition in 2021. They then fell out over the terms of integrating the RSF into the army — a question of who would command the merged force and on what timetable — and began fighting each other in Khartoum on **15 April 2023**. It is a war between two branches of the same security establishment over which one is the state. Neither is a rebellion, which is why there is no political process to join and no DDR framework to receive defectors.

DR Congo — east ↗

AFC/M23 retains Goma, Bukavu and most of the Kivu axis. Two parallel tracks — Doha for DRC–AFC/M23, Washington for DRC–Rwanda — are both alive and both slow. (US State Department joint statements, 12–13 and 17–21 Aug 2026)

24 Aug — first ceasefire verification mission of the Expanded Joint Verification Mechanism Plus, at Minembwe. The first real test of the Doha ceasefire architecture.

17–21 Aug — DRC and AFC/M23 agreed a roadmap sequencing negotiation of the Doha Framework protocols.

12–13 Aug — Sixth Joint Security Coordination Mechanism, Geneva. **DRC presented its DDR plan for the FDLR**, with MONUSCO operational input. Next JSCM 16–17 September; trilateral planning conference October 2026.

Jun — ADF conducted its deadliest anti-civilian month in Ituri since May 2022: 149 civilian fatalities. (ACLED, Jun 2026)

Drone strikes in eastern DRC: **65 in Jan–May 2026 alone against 56 in all of 2025**. (ACLED via IPIS, 25 Jun 2026)

Ordinance signal. FDLR disarmament is now a formal deliverable of the Washington track — the disarmament hinge of the entire Rwanda file. Whether it converts to actual cantonment and weapons collection, or stalls as previous P-DDRCS iterations did, is the thing to watch. Meanwhile the DRC mine action programme was cut from roughly 100 staff to a four-person team by the 2025 US funding freeze (ICBL-CMC, Jul 2025).

WHY IT STARTED

South Sudan became independent in 2011 and was at war with itself by 2013, along a split between President Kiir and Vice-President Machar that has been described in ethnic terms but is fundamentally about control of the state and its oil revenue. The 2018 agreement paused it by making Machar vice-president again while deferring every hard question — army integration, elections, the constitution. Machar's detention in March 2025 and the removal of the pre-election requirements in July 2026 removed what remained of the bargain. The current fighting is the 2013 war resuming with the pretence dropped.

The Sahel, Nigeria and the Lake Chad basin ↙

JNIM has shifted from rural insurgency to economic strangulation — fuel and transport blockades on Malian cities — while ISSP presses Tillabéri and has broken into north-west Nigeria. (ACLED, Dec 2025 & Jul 2026; OCHA, 29 Apr 2026)

Central Sahel humanitarian position: 2.8m internally displaced (2.1m Burkina Faso, 415,000 Mali, 283,000 Niger) plus 444,400 refugees; **2,640 conflict deaths in Q1 2026** across 1,179 security incidents; 3,794 schools and 974 health facilities non-functional. The 2026 requirement of US\$215m is **28% funded**. (OCHA, 29 Apr 2026)

Jun — JNIM ran forced **village-level disarmament** of Dozo self-defence militias in Mopti — non-state disarmament running against state DDR. Islamic State Sahel Province claimed its first Nigerian operations since 2019, in Kebbi and Sokoto.

Nigeria: Sokoto State recorded over 900 fatalities in the twelve months to mid-2026, more than double the preceding year; June 2026 was the deadliest month in Sokoto since ACLED began recording in 1997. US Africa Command has struck ISIS targets in Nigeria since 25 December 2025 at the request of Nigerian authorities; May 2026 strikes killed senior ISWAP figure Abu Bilal al-Mainuki. (ACLED, Jul 2026; AFRICOM; Al Jazeera, 18 May 2026)

2 Apr — ACLED data showed Burkinabè and Malian state forces killed more civilians than jihadist groups did. (Reuters, 2 Apr 2026)

Ordinance signal. On 1 June 2026 the UN High Representative for Disarmament Affairs stated that weapons looted from Libyan stockpiles in 2011 continue to circulate in Niger, Burkina Faso and Nigeria and have reached extremist hands, and separately flagged 3D-printed firearm components as an emerging untraceable-supply problem (UN News, 1 Jun 2026). Insurgent resupply is by capture: JNIM overran a Niger National Guard camp in June and seized significant caches. In Nigeria, returnees face explosive remnants in **11 of 15 return areas, where 80% of civilian EO casualties have occurred** (UN News, 3 Dec 2025). **Mali's mine action was zeroed out entirely by the 2025 US cuts and operations ended.** The African Union's PSSM project database for the Sahel dates from April 2019 and no comparably funded successor is identifiable.

WHY IT STARTED

Eastern Congo has not been at peace since the 1994 Rwandan genocide pushed the génocidaire forces — now the FDLR — across the border, drawing Rwanda and Uganda into two Congolese wars. M23 first rebelled in 2012, was defeated, and re-emerged in 2021 with Rwandan support that Kigali denies and UN experts have documented. The stated grievance is the protection of Congolese Tutsi and the unfinished business of the FDLR; the material stake is the mineral belt around Rubaya. This is why FDLR disarmament sits at the centre of the Washington track: it is the condition Rwanda names for withdrawing its own justification.

Somalia and the Horn

Somalia. Military stalemate, with al-Shabaab having recovered most 2022–23 government gains. **31 Jul** — AU member states agreed to accelerate the AUSSOM end date by 12–18 months; the US announced it will not renew the UN Support Office for 2027. **8 Aug** — the Somali National Army assumed control of Buurhakaba base from Ethiopian forces, held since 2014. **5–8 Aug** — Puntland forces captured the PSF headquarters in Galkayo, arresting 161 fighters. Presidential elections are postponed with no date; the incumbent's term ended in May. (ICG Briefing 212; Africa Center; Critical Threats, 13 Aug 2026)

Ethiopia. Live Fano insurgency in Amhara, OLA insurgency in Oromia, a TPLF that reinstated its 2020 regional government in May, and an Ethiopia–Eritrea relationship credible analysts describe as pre-war. Fighting erupted in **western Tigray in early August**; each side disputes who initiated. On 1 June, election day, Fano triggered over 90 clashes — more fighting than any single day since 2023. (ICG, 18 Feb 2026; ACLED, 2 Jun 2026; Al Jazeera, 7 Aug 2026)

Mozambique. Islamic State Mozambique was pushed out of its Catupa forest base and has dispersed south and west, spreading the threat into previously quieter districts and onto transport corridors. (ACLED Mozambique Conflict Monitor, Aug 2026)

Ordinance signal — the drawdown is itself the event. AUSSOM's accelerated withdrawal compresses base and materiel handovers to the Somali National Army, historically the highest-risk period for stockpile diversion and for creating unsecured depots. No corresponding physical-security or stockpile-management funding has been identified. Ethiopia's mine action programme was named among those facing suspension by March 2026 absent new donor commitments (UN News, 3 Dec 2025), with Tigray, Afar and Amhara carrying unsurveyed 2020–22 contamination.

WHY IT STARTED

The Sahel insurgencies began with the collapse of Libya in 2011, which sent weapons and Tuareg fighters south into northern Mali and triggered a rebellion in 2012 that jihadist groups captured. French and UN interventions contained it without ending it; coups in Mali (2020, 2021), Burkina Faso (2022) and Niger (2023) brought in governments that expelled Western forces and turned to Russian partners. Violence has risen since. Nigeria's north-east insurgency is separate in origin — Boko Haram's 2009 uprising — but the same Libyan weapons pool feeds both, and the two theatres have now physically joined in Sokoto and Kebbi.

Depot failures — the recurring event class

Not a conflict, but the failure mode that recurs across every theatre in this brief and the one most directly relevant to disposal capability.

1 Apr 2026 — Musaga depot, Bujumbura, Burundi. Explosions at the national defence force's main arsenal, sited in a dense residential area beside an officer training institute. **At least 13 killed, 57 wounded.** The army attributed it to an electrical short circuit; authorities publicly warned residents not to touch unexploded munitions scattered across neighbourhoods. (Reuters, 1 Apr 2026)

25 Feb 2026 — Border Patrol Police depot, Surin, Thailand. Multi-hour blasts near the Cambodian border; area evacuation ordered and EOD deployed. Officials named **heat acting on old ammunition stock** as the likely cause. (Al Jazeera, 25 Feb 2026; Nation Thailand)

31 May 2026 — TNLA depot, Kaung Tat, Shan State, Myanmar. **39 killed, 75 injured;** over half the village destroyed. (Al Jazeera, 31 May 2026)

16 Jul 2026 — Central Ammunition Depot II, Madiun, East Java, Indonesia. One soldier killed, six injured, during a personnel inspection. (Xinhua, 16 Jul 2026 — corroboration pending)

Ordinance signal. The Small Arms Survey's Unplanned Explosions at Munitions Sites database records **674 incidents between 1979 and December 2024** and was last updated in January 2025 — meaning **every incident above is outside the public dataset**. The pattern across all four is identical: ageing stock, hot climates, inadequate separation, personnel present at the point of failure, and no local capability to process material the site could not safely hold.

WHY THEY STARTED

Somalia: the state collapsed in 1991 and has not been reassembled; al-Shabaab emerged from the Islamic Courts Union after Ethiopia's 2006 intervention and has outlasted every external force sent against it — which is the relevant fact as AUSSOM winds down early for lack of funding. **Ethiopia:** the Tigray war of 2020–22 ended in an agreement that excluded Eritrea, which had fought in it, and excluded the Amhara Fano militias, which had also fought in it. Both are now sources of the current violence. Nothing about the 2022 settlement addressed western Tigray, which is where the August fighting is.

5 — ASIA-PACIFIC & THE AMERICAS

Myanmar ↙

Civil war at high intensity after a scripted election converted the junta into a nominally civilian government under Min Aung Hlaing as president. The military has regained battlefield momentum; the Arakan Army holds most of Rakhine. (ICG Briefing B188, 3 Jun 2026)

13 Aug — Kyaukphyu clashes resumed after a months-long pause, around the Chinese deep-sea port, SEZ and the origin of the Sino-Myanmar pipelines. The most likely trigger for direct Chinese intervention. (Burma News International, 13 Aug 2026)

20 Jul — the Arakan Army formally rejected the military's peace overtures; repeated airstrikes in Rakhine through July.

12 Jul — ASEAN held its first in-person meeting with a Myanmar foreign minister since the 2021 coup — a material softening of the non-engagement line.

Mar — the Brotherhood Alliance fractured: MNDAA assaulted TNLA positions at Kutkai and took the town, with Beijing silent throughout. Intra-resistance conflict is now a distinct axis. (ACLED, 23 Mar 2026)

16.2 million people in need; ~3.8 million internally displaced; the humanitarian plan is 43% funded. (OCHA Myanmar Update No. 52, to 13 Jul 2026)

Ordnance signal — the highest-value theatre in the region. Myanmar is the world's **second-worst country for mine/ERW casualties: 745 in 2025**, behind Syria (1,602) and ahead of Afghanistan (497) (ICBL-CMC preliminary data, Jun 2026). UNICEF separately recorded **169 incidents and 253 civilian casualties in Q1 2026 alone, 74 of them children** (UNICEF Myanmar, Jan–Mar 2026). *The two series use different methodologies and differ by roughly 30% — they are not interchangeable and are never combined here.* No DDR or weapons-handover programme exists; territorial transfers between armed groups move stockpiles between holders rather than reducing them.

WHY THIS KEEPS HAPPENING

Depot failures are not accidents of chance. Ammunition degrades — propellants become unstable with age and heat — and the states holding the largest legacy stocks are generally the ones least able to fund disposal. The result is that surplus accumulates in whatever building was available, often in a city, often for decades, until an electrical fault or a hot afternoon finishes the decision that was never made. Every case above involves stock a facility could not process and had no route to dispose of. This is the failure mode that a deployable destruction capability exists to prevent, and it is the one that reliably converts into procurement.

Thailand–Cambodia ↙

Second ceasefire, signed 27 December 2025, holding in the sense that large-scale fighting has not resumed — but eroding through landmine casualties and a diplomatic breakdown over maritime claims. (PBS/AP, 27 Dec 2025; ICG CrisisWatch, Jul 2026)

29 Jul and 17 Jul — Thai soldiers injured by mines in Sa Kaeo and Si Sa Ket provinces. Each incident has produced diplomatic escalation within 72 hours.

20 Jul — Thailand declared "the door is shut" on land-border talks after Cambodia initiated UN Convention procedures on the maritime claim; **23 Jul** — partially walked back.

16–20 Jul — Xi Jinping offered to mediate, which would displace Malaysian/ASEAN mediation.

The December round displaced approximately one million people across both sides at peak; the July 2025 round killed at least 38 and displaced ~300,000.

Ordinance signal. The 27 December ceasefire contains an explicit joint humanitarian demining provision covering the ~800 km border — a treaty-anchored clearance requirement between two states that were shooting at each other eight months ago. It is politically stalled, and the requirement grows with every month of stalemate. Thailand attributes casualties to newly laid mines; Cambodia denies new emplacement and cites legacy contamination. Both are claims; neither is independently verified. Cambodia has cleared 3,541 km² over 33 years and maintains a 2030 mine-free target set before the border districts were re-contaminated.

WHY IT STARTED

Myanmar's military has ruled for most of the period since 1962 and has fought ethnic armed organisations along its borders continuously since independence in 1948. The current war began with the coup of **1 February 2021**, which annulled an election the military's party had lost; peaceful protest was met with lethal force, and an armed resistance formed and allied with the older ethnic armies. The 2026 election and the "civilian" government it produced changed the label on the administration, not its composition. The landmine casualty figures are the highest in the world after Syria because all sides lay mines and no one clears them.

Afghanistan, Pakistan and the India–Pakistan file

Afghanistan. 17 Jul — the newly formed Sepah-e Maihan Front briefly captured the Yaftali-Payan district centre in Badakhshan: **the first Taliban loss of an administrative centre since September 2021** and the genuinely new development of 2026. 499 civilians were killed in Afghanistan–Pakistan fighting between October 2025 and June 2026 (UN). 2.56 million Afghans have returned since the November 2023 expulsion scheme (UNHCR). Mine/ERW casualties: 497 in 2025, third-worst globally. (ICG CrisisWatch, Jun–Jul 2026; ICBL-CMC, Jun 2026)

Pakistan. ICG issued a Conflict Risk Alert for June 2026: simultaneous TTP insurgency in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Baloch separatist violence, urban attacks in Karachi, and armed exchanges with Afghanistan. Pakistan is one of only two Asian countries on ACLED's 2026 watchlist. Arms imports up 66%, **80% from China**. (ICG, Jun 2026; ACLED, 11 Dec 2025; SIPRI, 9 Mar 2026)

India–Pakistan. No renewed cross-border exchange since the 2025 crisis, but the escalation vector has migrated from Kashmir to water. On **14 August** PM Sharif declared water a "red line" over India's continued holding of the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance; India replied the same day that there would be "no change." (Indian and Pakistani press, 14 Aug 2026 — regional sourcing, wire confirmation not obtained) Water is a harder problem than the Line of Control: continuous rather than episodic, with no ceasefire mechanism.

Ordinance signal. The 2021 US/ANDSF materiel inheritance in Afghanistan remains uninventoried in open sources, with multiple armed factions now operating from that stock and no DDR mechanism of any kind. Any figure circulating on its scale should be treated as unverifiable.

WHY IT STARTED

The Thai–Cambodian border was drawn by French colonial mapping in 1907 and has been disputed ever since, most sharply around the Preah Vihear temple, which the International Court of Justice awarded to Cambodia in 1962 and again in 2013 without settling the surrounding land. Fighting flared in 2008–11 and again in **July 2025**, then more heavily in December 2025. Two ceasefires later, the shooting has stopped and the mines have not — and Cambodia's move to arbitrate the maritime boundary in June 2026 froze the land-border committee that was supposed to deal with them.

Korea, Taiwan and the South China Sea ↙

Korea. 20 Aug — the DPRK fired more than ten short-range ballistic missiles, assessed as 600mm KN-25 multiple rocket launchers, ~300 km east, as Ulchi Freedom Shield wound down. That exercise ran in shortened form on President Trump's order. It was the DPRK's twelfth missile event of 2026. Seoul assesses DPRK warheads at 80–120. On **3 July** Kim ordered the new 5,000-tonne destroyer *Kang Kon* operational within two months — i.e. early September. (Al Jazeera, 20 Aug 2026; ICG CrisisWatch, Jul 2026)

Taiwan. PLA fighter sorties near Taiwan hit a three-year low — 1,334 in H1 2026 against more than 5,400 air sorties across 2025 — while coast guard and research vessel sightings rose 120% year-on-year in June. Japan's FY2025 scrambles against Chinese aircraft fell to 366, the lowest since 2012. **Read this as a change of method, not de-escalation:** two independent official sources show air activity falling and maritime law-enforcement pressure rising. Taiwan's defence spending rose 14% in 2025 and arms imports 54%. (Taiwan MND; Japan MoD, 17 Apr 2026; SIPRI)

South China Sea. Active grey-zone confrontation continues, non-kinetic: **23–24 Jul** — China Coast Guard used water cannon against Philippine vessels near Scarborough Shoal on two consecutive days; **20 Jul** — Manila alleged a CCG baton strike on a navy member near BRP Sierra Madre, Beijing alleged Philippine ramming. Mutually inconsistent claims, neither verified. (Al Jazeera and CNN, 24 Jul 2026; ICG, Jul 2026)

Ordinance signal — the region's live DDR opening. MILF decommissioning in the Philippines is the largest active weapons-handover programme in Asia and it is currently frozen — the MILF deferred the final phase in July 2025, and a government precondition was addressed with a peace-panel appointment on 15 July 2026. **The first-ever BARMM parliamentary elections on 14 September 2026 are the forcing event.** A restarted Phase III handover produces decommissioned firearms and ammunition requiring verified destruction. Separately: estimates of DPRK artillery ammunition supplied to Russia range from six to twelve million rounds, all attributed to intelligence assessments and mutually inconsistent — they are named, never asserted, and never given as a single number.

WHY THEY STARTED

Afghanistan: the Taliban returned to power in August 2021 as US and allied forces withdrew, inheriting the previous government's arsenal; the armed opposition now forming against them is new, and is the first since 2021. **Pakistan:** the TTP is a domestic Pakistani movement that regained sanctuary in Afghanistan after 2021, which is what Pakistan's cross-border strikes are aimed at; Balochistan's separatist insurgency is older and unrelated. **India–Pakistan:** both claim Kashmir since partition in 1947 and have fought four wars over it. The 2025 crisis ended without settling anything, and India's suspension of the 1960 Indus Waters Treaty moved the dispute to water — which, unlike the Line of Control, has no ceasefire mechanism.

The Americas

Haiti. Gang control persists over roughly 70% of Port-au-Prince. The UN-authorised Gang Suppression Force, ceiling 5,550 personnel under UNSC Resolution 2793, had roughly 1,000 personnel on the ground as of the July Council briefing, with full operational capacity not expected before October 2026. Jan–Mar 2026: 1,642 killed, 745 injured, with 69% of casualties attributed to security-force operations. 1.47–1.5 million displaced. Elections have slipped to January 2027. **24 Aug** — a Viv Ansanm attack on Kenscoff killed at least 30. (Security Council Report, Jul 2026; Al Jazeera, 24 Aug 2026)

Colombia. "Total Peace" is over. President de la Espriella, inaugurated 7 August, has ended negotiations in favour of a military-first approach. Armed group membership nearly doubled between 2022 and 2025 — from 15,132 total members to ~27,000, and from 7,620 armed combatants to 13,794. Combat operations rose from 447 in 2024 to 563 in 2025. Eight dialogue tracks were active when the previous president left office. (ICG Briefing 56, 7 Aug 2026)

Regional. 17 Aug — the US Defense Secretary announced agreements permitting joint US military operations on land in Colombia, Guatemala and Honduras, extending a campaign that AP reports has killed 200+ people in 60+ boat strikes since 2 September 2025. Guatemala had publicly denied agreeing to such strikes on 28 May — the two statements are in direct tension and are presented here as contested. Mexico has resisted a US military role on its own soil. (AP, 17 Aug 2026; Al Jazeera, 28 May 2026)

Ordinance signal. The Americas file is a **seized-property** problem rather than a battlefield-ordnance one: firearms, ammunition and narcotics moving into state custody through interdiction, with destruction obligations attached and thin published capacity. The US State Department's conventional weapons destruction programme reports more than \$197m regionally since 1993 — but the public figures are FY2019–FY2020 vintage on an unrevised page and should not be read as current.

WHY THEY PERSIST

None of these is a war, and that is the point. **Korea's** 1950–53 war ended in an armistice, not a peace treaty — the state of war is legally unresolved, which is why every exercise cycle produces a missile response. **Taiwan** is the unfinished business of the Chinese civil war of 1949; Beijing claims it, Taipei governs it, and the question has been deferred rather than answered for seventy-seven years. **The South China Sea** disputes are overlapping maritime claims that a 2016 arbitral award decided in the Philippines' favour and China rejects. All three are conflicts in which the parties have chosen, so far, to compete below the threshold of force — with water cannon, coast guards and sorties rather than munitions.

6 — WHAT THIS MEANS FOR TWB

The asymmetry is the opportunity.

2026 has produced a fully documented, well-funded global effort to *create* munitions — NATO identifying up to \$145bn in shared munitions and air-defence requirements (NATO Annual Report 2025, presented 26 Mar 2026), the EU committing over €700m of a €1.5bn programme to counter-drone systems, missiles and ammunition (EDIP Work Programme, 30 Mar 2026), Russia at seventeen times its 2021 shell output (Estonian FIS, 10 Feb 2026), and global arms transfers up 9.2% (SIPRI, 9 Mar 2026). Against that, there is **no corresponding published policy line or funding stream for destroying surplus**. International mine-action funding fell 5% in 2024 to \$761m, the largest donor cut deeply in 2025, and programmes in Mali, Angola and Zimbabwe were terminated outright while the DRC's went from ~100 staff to four. That gap — production scaling, disposal contracting — is the structural market. It is stated here as an observation about an absence of evidence, not as a forecast of tonnage.

Where it converts into demand TWB can actually serve. Vault's wedge is custody: destruction inside the owner's perimeter, same day, by the owner's own people. That is worth something specific in four situations this brief documents, and worth nothing in the rest.

1. Disarmament agreements with no destruction mechanism. Türkiye's PKK law is inert until the National Security Council certifies full weapons surrender, and **no verification or destruction mechanism has been named**. Gaza's decommissioning agreement provides for weapons to be stored under Palestinian custody, not destroyed — and the political objection to destruction there is about *who* takes the material, which is exactly the objection custody-preserving destruction answers. Iraq's militia handover lost its deadline this month with no disposal modality ever specified. The DRC tabled an FDLR DDR plan on 13 August. The Philippines' MILF handover restarts or does not on 14 September. Each of these is a case where the weapons exist, the political agreement exists, and the physical means of finishing the job is unnamed.

2. Depot failure as a procurement trigger. Burundi (13 killed, April), Myanmar (39 killed, May), Indonesia (July), Thailand (February) — four fatal or evacuation-grade events in seven months, none of them yet in the Small Arms Survey dataset, which stops at December 2024. The pattern is uniform: ageing stock, no local processing capability, personnel present when it fails. Lebanon is the sharpest version — six LAF soldiers killed in August 2025 destroying seized Hezbollah ammunition in the field. Historically these events, not policy papers, are what move a defence ministry to buy destruction capacity.

3. Institutional buyers already destroying at scale. UNMAS South Sudan has destroyed 7.3 million small-arms ammunition items, funded through **UN peacekeeping assessed contributions** — not discretionary donor money. That is the clearest evidence in this brief that a funded, recurring institutional buyer for exactly TWB's category exists. It also sets the realistic scale expectation: nine teams, two decades.

4. Seized property, not battlefield ordnance. The Americas file is interdiction-driven — firearms, ammunition and narcotics entering state custody with destruction obligations attached and thin published capacity. This is the nearest analogue to TWB's existing law-enforcement work and the least dependent on any conflict resolving.

Watch items for the next 30 days, in order of consequence to TWB. (1) Whether Türkiye's National Security Council certifies PKK disbandment and whether any destruction mechanism is named with it. (2) The BARM elections on 14 September and whether MILF Phase III restarts. (3) Whether Gaza's decommissioning modality moves from storage toward destruction. (4) UNIFIL's 31 December termination and who inherits EOD and cache disposal south of the Litani. (5) The 16–17 September DRC Joint Security Coordination Mechanism and the FDLR DDR plan's fate. (6) Whether the US Sudan-wide arms embargo proposal advances at the Security Council.

What this brief does not support, and should not be used to claim. None of the above is a tonnage forecast. Conventional demil is scored on tons per year, where a trailer-scale system does not compete, and nothing here changes that — the argument remains rounds destroyed without leaving the compound. Post-conflict clearance funding is *falling*, not rising, so "more war means more clearance money" is the wrong read; the correct read is that clearance demand is rising while clearance funding falls, which favours cheap, deployable, low-overhead capability over programme-scale operators. And in every live disarmament case above, the decision is political first and technical second: the buyer is a government that needs to be seen not to hand its opponents' weapons to anyone. That, not throughput, is the door.

Sources used. UCDP/Uppsala · ACLED · PRIO · SIPRI · IISS · UN OCHA, UNHCR, UNMAS, UNODA, UNICEF, IOM, OHCHR · IPC · ICRC · IAEA · OPCW · International Crisis Group · Security Council Report · ICBL-CMC / Landmine & Cluster Munition Monitor · GICHD · MAG · HALO Trust · Small Arms Survey · Congressional Research Service · US Department of War Inspector General · NATO · European Commission · Estonian Foreign Intelligence Service · national defence and foreign ministries · Reuters, AP, AFP, BBC, Al Jazeera, NPR, FT.

Figures deliberately excluded from this edition because they could not be traced to a primary source, or are belligerent claims: Sudan's "59,000 killed"; a cumulative Gaza death toll since October 2023; "4,300 killed in Lebanon since 2 March" and "1 million displaced in Lebanon"; the \$70bn Gaza reconstruction estimate; the Cobasna "Hiroshima-equivalent" characterisation; "EU 155mm capacity of 2 million rounds/year"; all Ukrainian and Russian personnel casualty claims; Congolese government figures from the Uvira occupation; Burkinabè "400 militants killed"; Mexican homicide-decline percentages; and any single figure for DPRK artillery transfers to Russia.

Known gaps carried into the next edition. Libya mine-action and stockpile data; Western Balkans SALW destruction tonnages; the Somalia and Sudan UN Panel of Experts current reports; DRC 2026 national displacement; Laos/Vietnam UXO funding position; UNMAS Afghanistan and Myanmar clearance output; Cameroon's Anglophone regions, where no current data was found at all. Two corrections were applied at verification and are noted in-line: Poland's Mine Ban Convention withdrawal took effect 20 February 2026 (not 26 February), and Türkiye's parliamentary vote was 10 August 2026 (not 11 August). Iraq's September weapons-surrender deadline was removed after both the PM's security adviser and the government spokesman disavowed it on 21–24 August.

Cadence. Updated every morning at 06:00 Eastern. Changes to each conflict appear as dated bullets beneath that conflict's status line. Where a status line itself changes, the previous status and the date it was superseded are retained.